Constructing the blank

1 Cut six pieces of 19mm plywood 130 x 150mm on the bandsaw, together with a piece of 25mm padauk the same size. Lightly sand the pieces before gluing them into a block using PVA adhesive. Lightly clamp the block and leave overnight to cure. It is essential that glued up blocks are secure before turning begins. Use a good quality glue and allow adequate time for it to cure thoroughly before beginning work on the assembly

2 Once set, draw the shape of the hollow form onto the block, using a paper template as a guide. Then, cut the block close to the line using the bandsaw – remember to retain the waste at the narrow end of the block

3 Next, remove further corners on the bandsaw before mounting the rough block between centres on the lathe. I find that a steb centre is ideal for mounting this sort of work and is very 'forgiving' if a catch does occur

Roughing down

4 Tidy up the waste end of the form and cut a dovetail spigot so the piece can be held securely for hollowing. The long point of the skew is already the correct shape for cutting a dovetail and I usually employ it for this purpose. Before reversing the form, use a 13mm bowl gouge to remove the corners and turn the piece to something resembling its final shape. This helps the piece to turn true and reduces vibration which might otherwise cause the spigot to break up. Leave plenty of wood at the end of the form near to the spigot as this will form a strong support for the piece. Reducing this end of the form to its final diameter will be one of the last tasks carried out

5 Reverse the blank and grip the dovetail spigot in the standard jaws of a four-jaw chuck. This enables a 30mm hole to be bored to a depth of approximately 115mm. A good quality Forstner bit will make this job much easier, so it is worth investing in quality cutters. Note the thick pencil line marking what will be the widest part of the hollow form as a reminder not to remove material from the outside in this area

Hollowing

6 Begin hollowing with the 13mm bowl gouge. Feed the gouge into the hole with the flute downwards. In this position the gouge cannot cut and you can feel your way down the wall of the hole. When you are a little way in, start to rotate the gouge slowly clockwise. This will bring the lower cutting edge of the gouge into contact with the wall. Continue rotating the gouge until you get a satisfactory cut. Don't over-rotate the gouge or you are very likely to get a dig-in which will not be pleasant, at best

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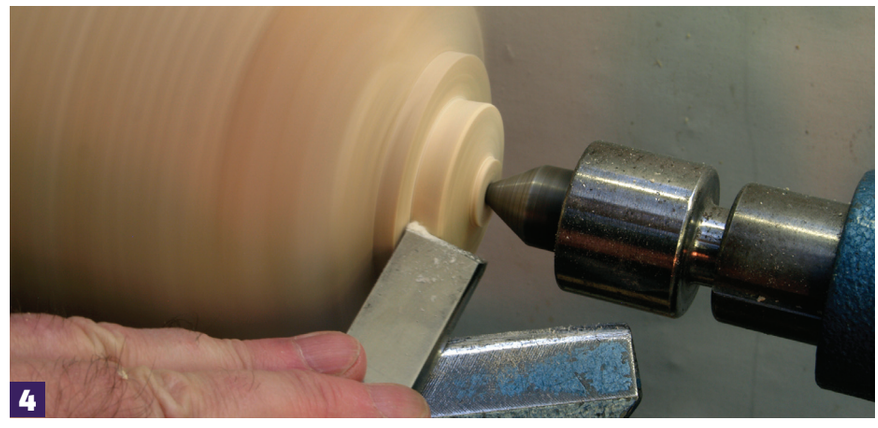
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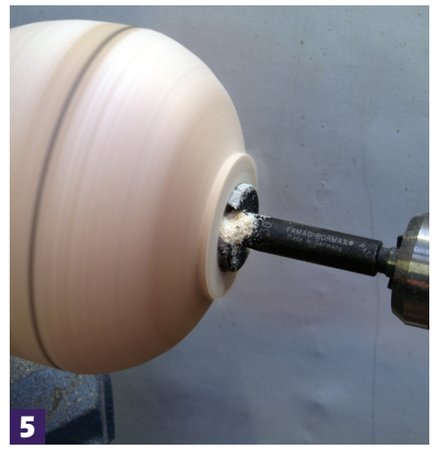
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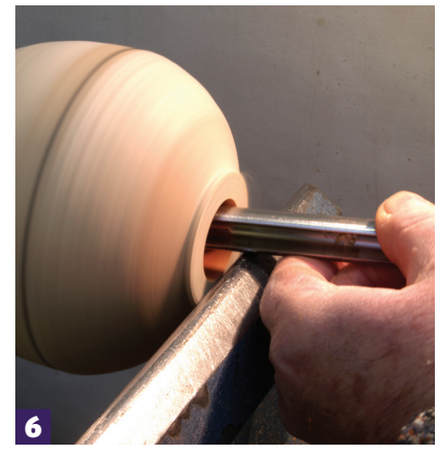
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